1. ***Discuss the reflexive move in anthropology; its meaning, main concerns, various outcomes (orientations), and impact for the future of the discipline. Illustrate with readings, videos, and class discussions.***

Introduction

The reflexive move in Anthropology, which began in earnest in the 80's likely inspired by the seminal work of Michel Foucault, is indicative of the critical juncture at which the discipline finds itself today. Anthropologists amassed over the centuries a massive body of knowledge on the human condition, on human societies, cultures, customs and rituals, yet Anthropology finds itself pondering the proverbial dilemma: Where do we go from here? As a discipline it must decide as to whether to continue to position itself in the Liberal Arts domain as a value free social science or become an engaged and empowered ethnography. Bob Scholte would define it as transitioning from the traditional and disciplinary to the urgent and substantive.

My theory is that Anthropology's traditional course has practically run its course. I agree with Scholte that epistemology reflection must complement if not precede scientific activity. Furthermore, and having not earned the scholastic credentials to be as presumptuous, I will nevertheless suggest that anthropologists at this juncture have an opportunity to become honest brokers in exposing if not ameliorating human suffering. They can do so by advocating for the under privileged as they spend the majority of their time in the field and close to the populations that are being neglected by the Western elite. In fact the recent trend towards applied anthropology is a welcomed start for the future of the discipline.

A discipline in search of a purpose

As an extension of Natural History, anthropology began as a study of the "colonized primitives" and only in 1904 evolved into a scholastic social sciences discipline in the Liberal Arts at Columbia University under the leadership of Franz Boas who himself came from the Museum of Natural History and is credited with taking the discipline from the museums to the

universities. In the 70's the discipline under the influence of Marxism and post colonialism moved away from the study of savages to studying urban societies. In the 80's began the reflexive move followed in the 90's, by a new trend, that of native anthropologists who study their own societies and cultures. To substantiate the theory one has only to agree that the study of human beings by human beings cannot possibly be objective and value free. I agree with Scholte that value free anthropology that is objective science with no prejudices, superstitions, irrationalities, and only facts, predictions is de-facto unattainable. In writing my own ethnography on my journey as a secular into ultra-orthodox territory I can attest to the fact that ethnographic descriptions are contextual, dialectical, situated and genuinely comparative. Things are not always what they look like. The "native artistry of disguise" is always at play. Exotic dress, feathers, grass skirts are used more to satisfy the Western appetite for authenticity and the exotic. Similarly, the anthropologist cannot avoid inserting their emotions (empathy, disgust, anger) or their agendas (Ortner's female2female) into their ethnographic descriptions. In a recent excursion to Rwanda my wife and I were treated to an "authentic" tribal dance performance with exotic dress and weapons. Later that evening I recognized the waiter at our table dressed in full European garb as one of the dancers. Beth Conklin describes this phenomenon more eloquently in her article "Body paint, feathers and VCRs." Sherry B. Ortner confirms that activist agendas have found their way into scholastic articles. It's time the discipline face the fact that everyone has an agenda which leads me to my argument: let us stop pretending that we are dealing with value free science. Victor Turner and his students, focused on the study of reflexive moments in social life. Turner was interested in the ways in which social action was accomplished through the manipulation of symbols. This is a good example for anthropologists who could and should exercise responsibility when studying societies, populations etc., and in the process discovering

injustices, suffering and discrimination. Morally, they can no longer just report on it as observers only in order to maintain their status as “scientists”. When we focus on the scientific meta-language we run the risk of losing sight of the interactive reality. Terrence Taylor spent 30 years with the Kayapo in the Amazon region. But it was only in the 90's when he turned to activism using his anthropological knowledge and documentation he collected to advocate for Kayapo rights. Now that's applied anthropology at its best.

My advocacy is not that of turning anthropology into a new age form of activism. Instead it is for leveraging the anthropologist knowledge, authority and yes, power to expose and influence the search and implementation of pragmatic solutions. It is easier said than done, but creating a meaningful co-operation, exchange and knowledge transfer between NGO’s and Academia to facilitate the application of academic knowledge for the improvement of the human condition may be a step in the right direction.

2. ***For most people objects are inert. Discuss how anthropologists have shown that objects can indeed "speak" and "do." Analyze (compare and contrast) cases (contexts and purposes) in which objects of all kinds have entered various forms of exchange, have marked special occasions, alliances, and so on. Illustrate with readings, videos, and class discussions.***

Introduction

Many anthropologists, most prominently Marcel Mauss and especially Daniel Miller have substantiated in their writings that objects can and do indeed “Speak” and “Do” things. Their works focus on the material culture of consumption and the meaning of objects or commodities as having inalienable or alienable properties in the form of gifting, exchange, collection etc. The topic of consumerism, commodities and their cultural context has been fondly labeled the “anthropology of stuff”. Miller offers a framework within which to look at and study the meaning of objects: Objects as

“containers of meaning”; objects as a tool to mediate social relationships (e.g. gifts); objects from a perspective of their means and method of production and their ascribed or perceived value and objects as an extension of the self. Appadari refers to this as the “social life of things”. The premise and findings of this body of work clearly illustrate that objects as much as have “spirits” and that they do mean (different) things in different cultures, valued differently and in fact can actually “do” things (e.g. start wars, make peace, do magic and perform rituals).

The Anthropology of stuff

While this theory is almost intuitive from any layperson’s life experience it is worthy of further analysis. Objects not only have meaning but identical “objects” may have different or multiple meanings depending on their contextual orientation. A piece of cloth carried around by a toddler. Is it a textile commodity or is it the old “blankie” we all used to carry around everywhere? A female may be the recipient of love and devotion as a wife or partner and a giver of devotion as a mother or a sibling. Water in a bottle may be a container of fluids or in a different regime of value “untouched by nature” social beverage in exclusive health clubs (e.g. Fijian water). A stamp may be viewed as a form of currency for a service delivery or a rare collectible item for a stamp collector. Objects as containers of meaning are channels through which we are capable of inquiring customs and rituals. The meaning of masks, body paintings, feathers worn by indigenous tribes objectify the heretofore unwritten traditions of their society. Symbols of love (e.g. hearts) or hate (e.g. swastikas) are immediate communicators that trigger almost a universal emotional response. Who is this man who wares this crown? Oh, it is the king. Objects mediating relationships and the rituals surrounding them in both modern and primitive

societies such as gifts, barter exchanges and sacrifices mean, say and do things to enhance social relationships like friendships, kinships and even worship. Objects are often viewed from the perspective of their means or method of production. Would you acquire the latest version of Apple's iPad if you clearly knew that they are manufactured utilizing child labor? (Many people probably would). Would you share your seven-dollar Fijian water with a homeless person on a main street on a hot day? Are you aware of who benefits and who is being exploited in the production of this "luxury" object? Is an Armani pair of jeans really that superior in value and utility so as to command 5 times the price of a Levi's? Why would Congolese males spend their meager financial means to buy Armani suites? (Les Sapear). Finally objects as an extension of self: your family photo album, your high school or university year book, your Russian doll collection, your travel logs, the "authentic" African mask you purchased in your trip to Tanzania that is ominously hanging over you fireplace. What do they mean to you, why are they important, what do they say to others about you. You see objects have spirits and they do things. Next time, when you make a substantial purchase, ask yourself if you are doing it as a routine provisioning (e.g. groceries) as a treat for someone you care for – maybe yourself, as a gift to a friend, or a work of art to please your soul. Finally when you are in London and then in Washington D.C ask yourself why 10 Downing Street looks so much different than 1600 Pennsylvania Ave and what does it really mean if anything. If, however, you happen to be somewhere north of Vancouver Island in Canada or in Alaska and you understand a bit of Chinook – *potlatch* to you.

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